

Holly Johnson

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Lincoln, NE, USA

Design Systems Lead | Senior UX Designer & Developer

hollyjohnson.design

PROFESSIONAL SUMMARY

Design systems lead, designer and developer for 10+ years, most recently three and a half years of B2B SaaS at Penlink. Built Helios there from zero: a Figma component set published as an Angular library.

Owned the design architecture and wrote the code standards underneath it. Earlier, built NUcleus for the University of Nebraska System, development first, a multi-brand design system still in use.

Partnered with senior leadership to turn direction into work teams could build, including design system strategy and investment cases presented to the CPO and CTO.

WORK EXPERIENCE

Senior UX Designer | Penlink, Remote

01/2023 - 08/2026

- Built Helios from zero, introducing Figma at Penlink and writing the Angular library behind three investigative products, adopted through platform modes and non-breaking versioned releases.
- Architected 200+ tokens, 50+ components and 20+ patterns in Figma variables and SCSS. Normalized prop contracts, WCAG-informed ARIA, internationalization and RTL shipped to the US, Canada and Israel.
- Designed CoAnalyst, Penlink's in-product AI, with the lead designer across chat, report view, agent workflow, streaming states and refusal handling. Led the saved-prompt and prompt-gallery patterns.
- Wrote the code architecture and standards behind the system, carrying roughly four designers' decisions to 150+ engineers through review practice and QA automation against documented contracts.
- Applied Claude and MCP daily for repository and adoption scans, customer insight synthesis and documentation. Designed and built Orbit, AI prototyping tooling the whole design team used.
- Shaped the company rebrand with the team and carried it into the products through Helios, then mentored designers and moved component critique into standing UX reviews.

Digital Design System Specialist | University of Nebraska System, Lincoln, NE

04/2022 - 01/2023

- Continued the NUcleus design system: standards, components and support for teams building across 9 university brands, through a restructure that moved the role into the Office of the President.
- Gave the creative direction for the Office of the President and created reusable templates and digital assets that let internal teams produce materials in-house rather than through outside contractors.
- Presented design system and brand work to the marketing VP and mentored designers on the team.

Lead Web Designer / Developer | University of Nebraska System, Lincoln, NE

05/2018 - 04/2022

- Proposed NUcleus and built its front-end system from the ground up: vision, roadmap, ITCSS architecture, primitive, semantic and component layers in SCSS and Handlebars reference components.
- Partnered with CMS developers to integrate NUcleus across 9 university brands, giving more than 20 teams a shared foundation while preserving each organization's identity.
- Directed the system through its roadmap, standards, documentation and hands-on review, working with product managers and engineers to prioritize enhancements and support adoption.
- Started NUcleus on the Foundation framework and progressively replaced that dependency with custom SCSS and JavaScript as the system matured, without interrupting the sites already building on it.

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- Led Theorem, a high school learning platform, from observed workflows and usage data through product design and a Handlebars, HTML and SCSS reference build. Engineering rebuilt its five portals in React.
- Held brand authority granted to no one else in the university system. Led a team of three direct reports across design and front-end development for four years.

Web Designer / Developer | University of Nebraska System, Lincoln, NE 08/2017 - 05/2018

- Designed websites, applications and communications platforms with product managers and engineers, from user journeys and information architecture through wireframes and front-end build.
- Built the design and front-end foundation that became NUcleus.

Independent Consultant | Freelance, Lincoln, NE 01/2014 - Present

- Designed and developed the National Strategic Research Institute's 2024 biennial-report web experience from supplied report content for the DoD-designated center.

CORE SKILLS

Design systems strategy	Governance & standards	Design system evolution
Design token architecture	Component APIs & contracts	Versioned releases
Figma variables & libraries	Design-to-code	Design system tooling
Multi-brand theming	Reusable patterns	Multi-product architecture
Product design	Product development	Technical architecture
Artificial intelligence (AI)	AI-powered experiences	Agentic workflows
Interaction design	Information architecture	Usability & visual design

TECHNICAL SKILLS

Claude & Claude Code	MCP in daily practice	AI prototyping & validation
Angular & Angular CDK	HTML, CSS, SCSS	JSON
TypeScript & JavaScript	Design-to-code	Prototyping
WCAG & ARIA	Focus management	i18n, localization & RTL
Content design & UX writing	Voice & tone standards	Documentation

EDUCATION

Associate of Applied Science [AAS], Graphic Design and Media Arts | Southeast Community College 2016
Paralegal Studies, bachelor's coursework | Doane College

EARLIER EXPERIENCE & AWARDS

Adjunct Instructor Southeast Community College, Lincoln, NE	04/2017 - 12/2022
Communications Designer Nebraska Department of Education, Lincoln, NE	11/2012 - 03/2017
Legal Assistant, Legal & Enforcement Nebraska Liquor Control Commission	05/2005 - 11/2012
Prism Award, Consumer Marketing Campaigns American Marketing Association	05/2022